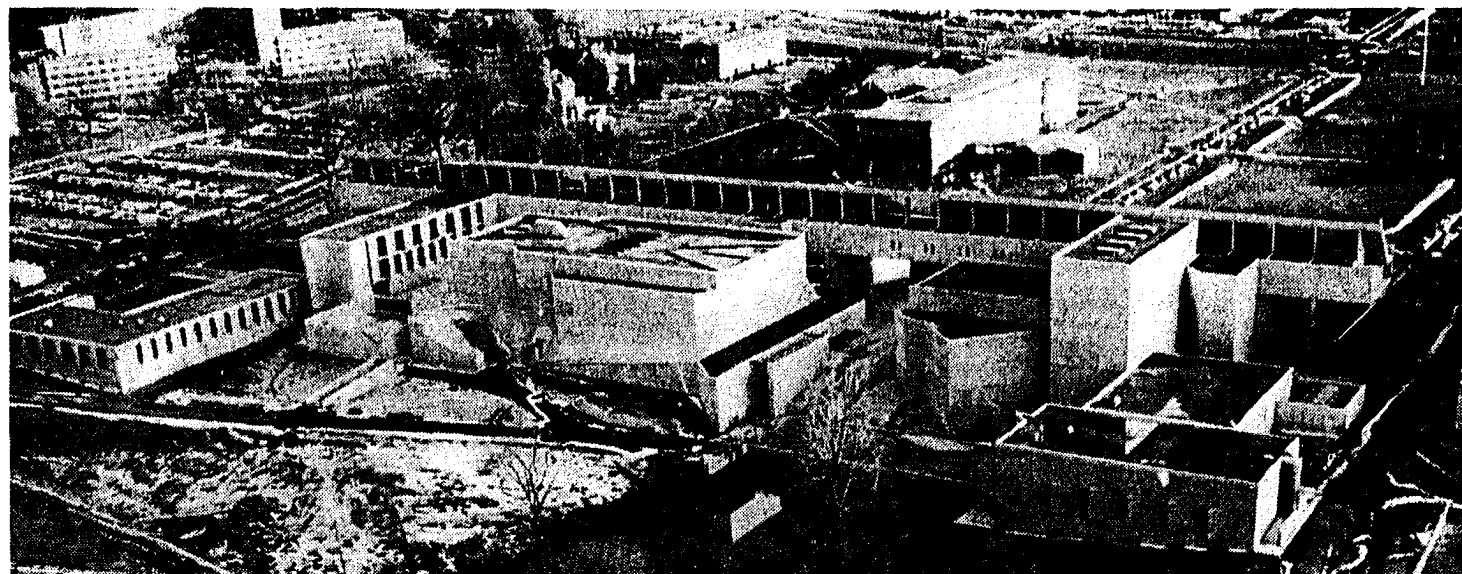


A prototype, but never to be repeated: ARCHITECTURE

Campbell, Robert

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Bridge of studios 650 feet long spans Kevin Roche's new Fine Arts Center at UMass Amherst, and serves as a pier onto which other parts of the

center are moored. One criticism is that the concrete is texture. (Robert Campbell photo)

A prototype, but never to be repeated

Of all today's architects, the one who always seems to come up with the biggest, boldest, most original ideas is Kevin Roche, the designer of the new Fine Arts Center soon to be opened at the University of Massachusetts campus at Amherst.

Roche got his start under the late Eero Saarinen and shares with that master the unsettling habit of trying to make every building a complete new departure. In the manner of an Oscar Wilde epigram, he often does this by taking a conventional idea and turning it upside down or inside out — literally.

For example, at one new office tower in Manhattan, Roche floats the building 120 feet in the air on stilts; at the Oakland Art Museum, on the other hand, he buries it underground. At the Ford Foundation headquarters in New York, the standard tower-in-a-plaza is turned inside out: the building wraps around the plaza. At the Knights of Columbus building in New Haven, the building itself is inside-out: the service core, normally at an office building's center, is split four ways and pushed out to the corners.

It's an approach that puts a lot of emphasis on coming up with that vital new twist, then stating it as boldly, as uncompromisingly, as possible. Every building becomes a prototype — but a prototype, paradoxically, that is destined never to be repeated.

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

At UMass Fine Arts Center the concept is as bold as ever. A boldly sculptured bridge of art studios, 650 feet long, runs the length of the site one story up in the air. Lining it on one side, like barges moored at a pier, is a varied mix of auditoriums, offices, theaters and workshops.

The whole thing is then sited in such a way that the bridge of studios becomes a kind of gateway to the campus: you pass beneath it, walk between two of the auditoriums, and emerge on the edge of the pond that forms the center of the campus.

Urbanistically, it's a brilliant concept. The straight line of the bridge gives a firm edge to the central campus and ties together the varied sizes and shapes of the auditoriums and theaters, which in turn reflect the variety and scale of the older buildings nearby.

Yet one can't be completely enthusiastic. The building suffers from a quality that is often pointed out in Roche's work. Entirely made of concrete, which is hand rubbed to make it as uniform as possible, the building is completely lacking in detail or texture.

A building like this raises the whole puzzling question of how a human being, looking at a building, senses a relationship to it, understands it as something more than an

inert mass of material. It helps if you can see where you can go in, or where, if you were inside, you could be looking out; if you can perceive, from the shape and detail of the exterior, what some of the activities are that take place inside; if, as you move toward the building, you can see a gradual unfolding of smaller and smaller details that step the building down to you in scale — from the whole building, to the room, to the window, the brick, the texture of the brick. All these things help you to building as a container of human activity, as something different from outdoor sculpture.

Enough of these qualities are missing in the UMass Fine Arts Center to leave it with a curiously blank quality. If it isn't too anthropomorphic to say it, you get the feeling that when you look at the building, it isn't looking back. It's faceless.

But even with this caveat, there remain many pleasures and lessons to be experienced in this complex. Great attention has been paid to realizing the potential of every interior space. The large auditorium, with balconies sweeping forward instead of back, is a wonderful space; so are the art studios.

Compared to the rest of UMass Amherst, a jumble of unrelated personal monuments that looks more

like a world fairgrounds than a campus, Roche's work is in a class by itself.

Yet one comes away wishing he could relax his search for singularity enough to fill in some of those small but vital missing links that would make a more human architecture.